Abdul Hakim, an Iraqi Shia leader considered to be a close friend of Rafsanjani, for a price that was immediately paid by the Indian spy agency in Baghdad. The meeting took place sometime in August 1985 at a R&AW safe house in Paris to avoid the CIA and Mossad's surveillance. Contact was established between Shirazi, Hakim and the Indian spy and it deepened.

Hakim was also running a Dervish group —followers of Sufism —in Paris. Vipul was invited to an evening of Sama meditation wearing a salwar and jameh with a wool skullcap. He later learnt that the group was primarily used by Hakim for intelligence collection in France and other European countries.

Between September and November 1985, Vipul and Hayyan made thirty-nine clandestine trips to Syria, Lebanon, Iraq and Afghanistan. On his three trips to Afghanistan to meet a powerful Shia leader, Vipul operated under the name of Khaled Faraj, a Kuwaiti businessman. The Afghan leader was flown to Beirut to meet Fadallah, carrying handsome gifts from the Indian agency. Vipul clarified that the Indian intelligence organisation never supported the activities of Hezbollah but they did not hesitate to take help from the leader widely considered to be a terrorist sympathiser.

Tn espionage, there is no colour of your asset as long as it suits your interest and the asset continues to stay in the shadows,' Vipul once explained to me.

He also made five trips to Baghdad and Najaf where a group of Shia leaders supported the Iranian revolution and covertly worked against Saddam Hussein, a close ally of India. However, any visit to Tehran was deliberately avoided so this operation had to be conducted from a third country.